

Toward the Importance of Nonprofit Brand Equity

RESULTS FROM A STUDY OF GERMAN NONPROFIT ORGANIZATIONS

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Various brand evaluation approaches assess the value and equity of for-profit brands; accordant approaches for nonprofit brands, however, have been limited, and there is disagreement on what makes up a strong brand in the nonprofit sector. In response, this article provides insights into the conceptualization and operationalization of stakeholder-based nonprofit brand equity and derives an initial measurement index. We conceptualize nonprofit brand equity as having three dimensions—nonprofit brand awareness, nonprofit brand trust, and nonprofit brand commitment—thereby empirically investigating trust in nonprofit brand equity building for the first time. The methodological procedure for building the index is based on partial least squares path modeling, and we draw on a sample of forty brands (N = 3,617 brand evaluations) identified as some of the best-known nonprofit brands in Germany. Applying the index yields some of the strongest German nonprofit brands; for example, German Red Cross has by far the highest value of brand equity, followed by Aktion Mensch and UNICEF. The nonprofit brand equity index provides the basis for nonprofit managers to compare their brands' performance over time and develop accordant branding strategies; it can be also used by organizations from other countries.

Keywords: *nonprofit brand evaluation, stakeholder-based nonprofit brand equity, nonprofit brand awareness, nonprofit brand trust, nonprofit brand commitment*

STRONG BRANDS PROVIDE ORIENTATION and quality for stakeholders, and evidence has affirmed these brands' relationship to important organizational outcomes such as greater stakeholder loyalty and better financial performance (Fischer, Völckner, and Sattler 2010; Gromark and Melin 2011). Considering the impact of marketing activities and their contribution to firm performance, the evaluation of brands has attracted growing attention (Christodoulides and De Chernatony 2010). Achieving a successful brand by strengthening brand equity (that is, the financial or psychological value of the brand) has been among the top research priorities in the past (Keller and Lehmann 2006), and both academic scholars and practitioners have developed a multitude of methodologies to determine the equity and value of brands in the

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for-profit sector (for an overview, see Christodoulides and De Chernatony 2010; Salinas 2011). With regard to the nonprofit sector, however, Wymer, Gross, and Helmig (2015) noted that there is uncertainty about what makes up a strong nonprofit brand, and despite the increasing awareness of brands' potential in the nonprofit sector, research on brand equity in nonprofit organizations remains sparse (for example, Faircloth 2005; Juntunen, Juntunen, and Autere 2013; Laidler-Kylander and Simonin 2009). In response, we aim in this study to conceptualize and operationalize nonprofit brand equity, thereby developing an initial brand equity index for nonprofit organizations, which we test empirically with a large data set from Germany.

We contribute to the overall discussion on nonprofit brand equity in three ways. First, despite the increasing awareness of the relevance of branding in the nonprofit sector (Laidler-Kylander and Stenzel 2013), insights into brand evaluation approaches on the strength of nonprofit brands have been limited, and most findings have come from market research and consulting firms. For example, the Nielsen Company (2015) ranks a series of US nonprofit brands from different categories according to their brand equity, and Cone Communications (2015), together with Intangible Business (2015), assesses the hundred leading US nonprofit brands using a combination of financial and stakeholder-related data. The latter identifies YMCA of America, the Salvation Army, and United Way of America as the best-performing nonprofit organizations in terms of high nonprofit brand value (Cone Communications 2015). The underlying methodologies, however, are strongly and, most often, fully aligned with brand evaluations in the for-profit sector. It follows, then, that corresponding rankings fail to reflect the public's response to cases of ethical misconduct in the nonprofit sector, such as YMCA's commercialization issues or massive losses of trust and relevance of United Way over the past years (Rhode and Packel 2009; Weisbrod 2004). That is, these brand evaluations mainly focus on brand equity from a financial perspective; yet financial performance is not the main objective in nonprofit organizations, and nonprofit scholars largely do not account for financial brand value, suggesting a stakeholder-based perspective instead. Accordingly, this study conceptualizes and operationalizes nonprofit brand equity from a stakeholder perspective, thereby contributing to the academic literature with initial insights into nonprofit brand evaluation approaches and accordant index construction.

Second, of the few existing academic studies on stakeholder-based nonprofit brand equity, almost all are based exclusively on for-profit models without any adaptation to the nonprofit context. Following Aaker's (1991) and Keller's (1993) common conceptualizations of customer-based brand equity, most nonprofit scholars have claimed that brand awareness, brand image, and brand personality are substantial dimensions of nonprofit brand equity (Becker-Olsen and Hill 2006; Faircloth 2005; Hou, Du, and Tian 2009; Juntunen et al. 2013). Laidler-Kylander and Simonin (2009), however, recommend distinguishing between nonprofit and for-profit brand building. In accordance, we question the full transferability of (for-profit) dimensions of the brand equity construct to the nonprofit sector. In contrast to most prior studies, then, this study approaches stakeholder-based nonprofit brand equity from the perspective of specific organizations' and brands' characteristics in the nonprofit sector. We conceptualize the construct to include communication and relationship-oriented dimensions that are relevant in exchange processes with nonprofit stakeholders.

Third, most academic studies on stakeholder-based brand equity in the nonprofit sector have provided a measurement based on one or a few selected nonprofit brands. For example, Becker-Olsen and Hill (2006) investigated the brand equity of two selected nonprofit brands, while other scholars examined single nonprofit brands with a case study approach

(for example, Faircloth 2005; Juntunen, Juntunen, and Autere 2013). Although such results yield insights into stakeholder-based brand equity conceptualizations and operationalizations, investigating the strength of a series of nonprofit brands reveals more information about nonprofit brands' evaluations. Therefore, we apply the nonprofit brand equity concept to forty of the best-known German nonprofit brands, thereby providing initial insights into nonprofit brand equity based on a large data set from Germany. In summary, two research questions guide this study:

RQ1: How can nonprofit brand equity be conceptualized (based on existing literature from the field of nonprofit and for-profit branding)?

RQ2: How can dimensions of nonprofit brand equity be operationalized and measured?

In the next section, we provide an introduction to nonprofit brands and the dominant brand equity perspectives in for-profit and nonprofit sectors that lead to our proposed conceptual framework. The methodological procedure for building the index is based on partial least squares (PLS) path modeling and a reflective–formative measurement approach, respectively. For a practical application, we drew on a sample of forty German nonprofit brands ($N=3,617$ brand evaluations) identified as some of the best-known nonprofit brands in Germany. After presenting the empirical results of our study, we discuss the findings and derive implications for researchers and provide nonprofit managers with practical suggestions to help strengthen their nonprofit brands.

Conceptualization of Nonprofit Brand Equity

To conceptualize stakeholder-based nonprofit brand equity, we first introduce a definition of nonprofit brands, and show the dominant brand equity perspectives in for-profit and nonprofit sectors. This provides the basis for our nonprofit brand equity framework, with its three dimensions: (1) nonprofit brand awareness, (2) nonprofit brand trust, and (3) nonprofit brand commitment.

Definition of Nonprofit Brand

The role of brand in the nonprofit sector has significantly changed over the past years, and nonprofit scholars and practitioners both recognize a paradigm shift in nonprofit branding (Kent 2015; Laidler-Kylander and Stenzel 2013). The “old” paradigm mainly considers the nonprofit brand a fundraising or communication tool, with a focus on the tangible elements of the brand such as its name or logo; more recently, the brand has risen to the level of a strategic asset (Kylander and Stone 2012). In this function, the nonprofit brand assumes a broader role in the organization, with the potential to internally provide guidance and further cohesion among staff and volunteers while externally offering orientation to various stakeholders (Hankinson 2004; Laidler-Kylander and Simonin 2009). Thereby, the brand functions as a source of efficiency that signals the organizational core values and principles to external stakeholders, allowing them to draw conclusions about the organization (such as regarding its trustworthiness and reputation) and, ultimately, its ability to further the mission. The nonprofit brand accordingly helps simplify stakeholder decision making and reduces risk in an increasingly complex environment (Laidler-Kylander and Stenzel 2013).

In line with the strategic understanding of brands, Kapferer (2012, 12) defines a brand as “a name that symbolizes a long term engagement, crusade, or commitment to a unique set of values, embedded into products, services, and behaviors, which make the organization, person or product stand apart or stand out.” In a similar vein, and given the brand’s specific characteristics in the nonprofit sector, we define a nonprofit brand as *one or more tangible elements that symbolize the nonprofit organization’s dedication to a unique set of values and its ability to achieve an overall mission that enables it to stand out from other organizations in the nonprofit sector.*

Perspectives of Nonprofit Brand Equity

The brand equity construct has been approached mainly from two perspectives. The first perspective refers to the financial (monetary) value of the brand, or what is known as an intangible asset in financial terms (for example, Salinas 2011; Simon and Sullivan 1993). This perspective considers the brand’s equity as the amount the brand is worth as ownership or as ongoing future income flows (Schultz 2003). Many popular brand valuation models, such as those from Brand Finance (2015) or Millward Brown (2015), adopt such a financial-based brand equity perspective and accordingly refer to the term “brand value.” In nonprofit organizations, however, financial performance is not the main objective, and scholars have claimed that financial-based measures are insufficient by themselves for evaluating their performance and success (Leipnitz 2014; Garven, Hofmann, and McSwain 2016). Rather, nonprofit organizations primarily rely on legitimacy and resources from stakeholders, which makes a stakeholder-based evaluation approach more appropriate (Shea and Hamilton 2015).

The second perspective focuses on the psychological value of the nonprofit brand, thereby centering the customer’s or, in our context, the stakeholder’s subjective perceptions of and attitudes toward the brand. This stakeholder-based brand equity perspective acknowledges the stakeholder’s important role in the branding process; Schultz (2000, 9) has noted that “the true value or equity of the brand resides in the customer’s valuation.” Related brand evaluation approaches attempt to measure how much value the stakeholder puts on the brand using attitudinal and behavioral measurement quantities (Schultz 2000). Aaker’s (1991) and Keller’s (1993) conceptualizations have had a decisive influence on this perspective. Aaker (1991, 15) described brand equity as “a set of brand assets and liabilities linked to a brand, its name and symbol that add to or subtract from the value provided by a product or service to a firm and/or to that firm’s consumers”; conversely, Keller (1993) highlighted the differential effect of brand knowledge on stakeholder perceptions, preferences, and behavior arising from branding efforts.

Moreover, a few other brand evaluation approaches combine both perspectives, including stakeholders’ perceptions of the brands and financial measures (for example, Interbrand 2015; Nielsen Company 2015). In general, Schultz (2003) has observed brand evaluation approaches from a broad spectrum, with a stakeholder-based perspective at one end (stakeholder-based brand equity) and a financial-based perspective at the other end (brand value); brand equity in for-profit sectors has been equally approached from both perspectives. In contrast, considering the stakeholder’s important role in the nonprofit sector, nonprofit scholars have almost exclusively examined nonprofit brand equity from a stakeholder-based perspective (for example, Faircloth 2005; Hou et al. 2009; Juntunen et al. 2013) or according to internal structures (Laidler-Kylander and Simonin 2009). Stakeholder-based nonprofit brand equity is also closely related to the concept of nonprofit brand strength (Wymer et al.

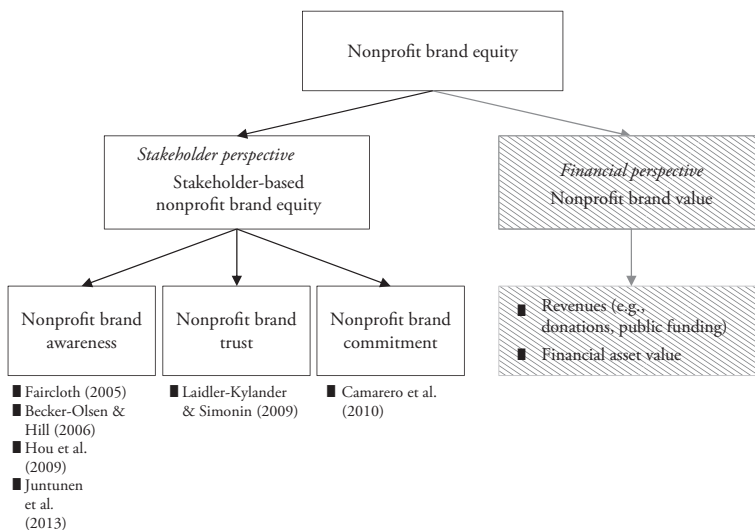
2015), which measures the stakeholder's attachment to a brand. As such, Wymer (2013) refers to nonprofit brand strength as a strategic component and diagnostic measure of brand equity in nonprofit organizations.

Nonprofit Brand Equity Framework

Figure 1 illustrates our nonprofit brand equity framework. Considering that a stakeholder-based perspective is more appropriate in nonprofit brand building, the outlined framework focuses on stakeholder-based brand equity only and refrains from assessing nonprofit brand value from a financial approach. Not only do stakeholders play a central role in the nonprofit sector, but organizations are also confronted with many stakeholder groups, including resource providers, the general public, government, and other subgroups. In this study, we particularly refer to the stakeholder in terms of the general public and accordingly conceptualize stakeholder-based nonprofit brand equity as having three dimensions: (1) nonprofit brand awareness, (2) nonprofit brand trust, and (3) nonprofit brand commitment. When evaluating brands, the first relevant dimension is its awareness among the public—that is, brand awareness is essential for establishing and strengthening brand-specific associations and building familiarity with the brand (Aaker 1991). As such, brand awareness is a substantial dimension of nonprofit brand equity (Faircloth 2005; Juntunen et al. 2013).

The majority of nonprofit scholars have further included brand image or brand personality, based on for-profit conceptualizations, as dimensions of nonprofit brand equity (Becker-Olsen and Hill 2006; Camarero, Garrido, and Vicente 2010; Faircloth 2005). Faircloth (2005), who first proposed this conceptualization, hypothesized that people are more likely to provide resources to nonprofit organizations when the organizations have positive brand

Figure 1. Nonprofit Brand Equity Framework



Note: Literature on the nonprofit brand strength concept is not integrated in this framework; see Wymer et al. (2015) for further conceptualization.

images and brand personalities. Within this context, Faircloth illustrates the importance of brand traits such as trustworthiness and a brand's background in allowing stakeholders to feel more comfortable with the brand. He accordingly operationalizes brand personality by considering the stakeholder's attachment to and trust in the brand. In accordance with Faircloth and other nonprofit scholars who build on this conceptualization, we believe that a brand's image and personality are of particular relevance for attracting potential resource providers in the nonprofit sector; yet evaluating brand equity in the nonprofit sector in terms of general positive associations with the brand might not be sufficient. Rather, we argue that the organization's and brand's specific characteristics in the nonprofit sector should be integrated more strongly, and thus we view public trust in brands, as a dimension of nonprofit brand equity, as a more thorough conceptualization. These conceptual considerations are consistent with findings from nonprofit governance literature that show that nonprofit organizations are particularly dependent on public trust because of their social-oriented and value-based missions (Kearns 2014; Prakash and Gugerty 2010). Besides, a series of recent media scandals in the nonprofit sector have reinforced the awareness of the high importance of public trust.

Although we consider brand awareness and brand trust substantial dimensions of nonprofit brand equity, these dimensions alone cannot sufficiently account for nonprofit brand equity, because they do not reflect the brand's ability to develop a stronger relationship (for example, in terms of high engagement) with stakeholders, which has been found to be of particular importance in the nonprofit sector. Therefore, we include nonprofit brand commitment in our conceptual framework. Several scholars, mostly in for-profit literature, have highlighted the relevance of relationship-related dimensions such as loyalty and commitment in the brand equity context, acknowledging that to build strong brands, stakeholders must feel close and attached to the brand (Aaker 1991; Camarero et al. 2010; Lassar, Mittal, and Sharma 1995; Martin and Brown 1990). In the nonprofit sector, a relationship orientation has been a priority because nonprofit organizations are highly dependent on strong relationships with stakeholders, which translate into positive outcomes, including donations of time and money (Arnett, German, and Hunt 2003; Boenigk and Scherhag 2014). Because this article considers stakeholders in terms of the general public, we integrate nonprofit brand commitment in our framework, instead of the more frequently used concept of brand loyalty, because we focus on the perceptual dimensions of nonprofit brand equity. These conceptual considerations are consistent with Martin and Brown's (1990) and Lassar et al.'s (1995) conceptualization of commitment as a perceptual rather than a behavioral dimension of brand equity. Each nonprofit brand equity dimension ultimately builds on the previous dimension, similar to the relationship cycle between the stakeholder and the brand. Following, we clarify the underlying rationale of each nonprofit brand equity dimension.

Nonprofit Brand Awareness

Nonprofit brand awareness constitutes an elementary dimension of nonprofit brand equity (Faircloth 2005; Juntunen et al. 2013) and is considered a prerequisite for further engagement with the brand, such as the development of brand trust (Keller 2003). Brand awareness refers to the stakeholder's ability to recall and recognize the brand (Rossiter and Percy 1987) and thus indicates the strength of the anchor point of the brand in memory (Aaker 1991). Accordingly, widespread public awareness is essential for nonprofit organizations, and a well-known nonprofit brand can serve stakeholders through its signaling function as an orientation aid (with respect to the organization's values and for decisions on whether to support the organization or not) (Ritchie, Swami, and Weinberg 1999). Yet a strong nonprofit brand might be well

known to the public or certain stakeholder groups but might still yield negative associations for stakeholders (for example, in the case of a nonprofit scandal) and therefore be rather weak in nature (see Wymer et al. [2015] in the context of brand familiarity). Thus, the authors assert that a strong nonprofit brand must also be perceived favorably, which leads into our second dimension.

Nonprofit Brand Trust

Considering the prominent role of trust in discussions about governance and accountability in the nonprofit sector, high levels of trust are necessary for nonprofit organizations because their behavior and performance are often difficult to observe (Kearns 2014; Prakash and Gugerty 2010). It follows that stakeholders rely heavily on public trust when interacting with nonprofit organizations, such that they must be able to rely on the organization to remain true to its promised values and to carry out its mission successfully. Regarding the nondistribution constraint (Hansmann 1980), according to which nonprofits are not allowed to distribute profit to private parties, the existence of nonprofit organizations is assumed to be based on trust inherent in nonprofits, and people are more likely to trust nonprofit than for-profit organizations because of both their mission orientation and the nondistribution constraint. Within this context, we argue that brand trust is related to accountability, with the brand's function to reduce stakeholders' risk of engaging in disagreeable exchange relationships with the organization (Keller 2003).

Despite its crucial role in the nonprofit sector, trust has hitherto played a minor role in the nonprofit brand equity discussion. Consistent with the aforementioned considerations, this article views brand trust as a central dimension of nonprofit brand equity. In an explorative study, Laidler-Kylander and Simonin (2009) provided first insights into the importance of trust. They proposed an initial model of nonprofit brand equity and identified trust as a key dimension that drives brand equity in international nonprofit organizations and helps differentiate nonprofits from competitors. Regarding the development of strong stakeholder-brand relationships, scholars have claimed that in addition to trust, emotional closeness is relevant, and studies have found that nonprofit brand trust affects the emotional and relationship-related nonprofit brand commitment (Sargeant and Lee 2004), which leads into our third dimension.

Nonprofit Brand Commitment

When stakeholders become emotionally attached to a nonprofit brand, they form a relationship with it (Sargeant and Lee 2004) and develop a sense of commitment. Nonprofit brand commitment reflects a person's attitude and behavior toward the organization based on a strong belief in and acceptance of an organization's goals and is characterized by "an enduring desire to maintain a valued relationship" (Moorman, Zaltman, and Deshpandé 1992, 316). Therefore, brand commitment and other related relationship dimensions, such as brand loyalty, are of particular importance in the context nonprofit brand equity (Camarero et al. 2010).

Nonprofit managers and scholars have focused extensively on the management of relationships, primarily with donors, in the past and treated the development of strong organization-stakeholder relationships with priority (Boenigk and Scherhag 2014). That is, strong exchange relationships enhance the strategic options for nonprofit managers, encouraging them to cooperate with stakeholders and maintain a long-term orientation that subsequently promotes the organization's performance (Kemp, Jilapalli, and Becerra 2014). Arnett et al.'s

(2003) identity salience model of relationship marketing posits that a relationship marketing orientation is a viable strategy for nonprofit organizations to develop successful exchange relationships with stakeholders.

Taken together, our conceptual framework ultimately builds on the assumption that nonprofit brand awareness, nonprofit brand trust, and nonprofit brand commitment contribute to stakeholder-based brand equity in the nonprofit sector. Accordingly, high nonprofit brand equity, which equals strong nonprofit brands, occurs when all three components are high by themselves, and organizations with corresponding traits have been found to enjoy higher reputations (Mitchell 2015). It follows that a strong brand indicates that the organization is well known by a multitude of stakeholders, and that people believe in the organization's trustworthiness and credibility and are ultimately dedicated to the organization. Considering these components, we argue that high brand equity in nonprofit organizations acts as an additional safeguard and reinforcement to the public of what the nondistribution constraint is supposed to do. Precisely, recent cases of fraud and mismanagement in the nonprofit sector have challenged the notion of inherent trust and credibility in nonprofit organizations, so that scholars doubt the power of the nondistribution constraint to successfully mitigate the effects of these scandals (Prakash and Gugerty 2010). It follows that the nondistribution constraint by itself may not fully prevent opportunistic behavior, and nonprofit organizations might use additional mechanisms to signal credibility. By providing stakeholders a "shortcut" of what the organization is about (Laidler-Kylander and Stenzel 2013), the brand provides valuable information and thereby reduces stakeholders' risk of engaging in disagreeable exchange relationships with the organization (Keller 2003). Accordingly, the nonprofit brand functions as a kind of trust and quality seal. Given the increasing number of cases of ethical misconduct in the nonprofit sector, strong brands can protect against negative spillover effects caused by these cases, and the organizations are less susceptible to risk.

Operationalization of Nonprofit Brand Equity

To operationalize stakeholder-based nonprofit brand equity, we conducted a two-stage methodological approach, measuring the nonprofit brand equity dimensions in the first step and evaluating the overall construct of nonprofit brand equity in the second step. This procedure led to our proposed brand equity index for nonprofit organizations.

Measurement of Nonprofit Brand Equity Dimensions

Building on established scales, we measured the three nonprofit brand equity dimensions (see Table 1). We operationalized nonprofit brand awareness as the recall and recognition dimension of the brand that can be assessed through unaided and aided measures. Therefore, we measured unaided brand awareness by means of an open-ended question; for aided brand awareness, we showed respondents the brand names and logos of all nonprofit organizations, using a dichotomous question. We further operationalized brand trust and brand commitment using a reflective measurement approach and seven-point rating scales anchored by "Strongly disagree" (1) and "Strongly agree" (7).

Before building the index, we tested the scales' psychometric properties (reliability and validity). Cronbach's alpha for both constructs exceeded Nunnally's (1978) suggested threshold

Table 1. Operationalization, Descriptive Statistics, and Measurement Quality

Measurement Items	M	SD	AVE	CR	α
Nonprofit Brand Awareness					
<i>Unaided Nonprofit Brand Awareness:</i> In Germany, there is a variety of nonprofit organizations that work for charitable and nonprofit purposes, including the collection of donations. These are all those organizations that are neither economic companies nor public authorities. What nonprofit brands do you know?					
<i>Aided Nonprofit Brand Awareness:</i> You see several nonprofit brands below. Please tick all nonprofit brands that you were already familiar with before starting this survey.					
Source: Based on Keller (1993), Aaker (1996)					
Nonprofit Brand Trust			0.88	0.96	0.93
I trust this nonprofit brand to always act in the best interests of the cause.	5.12	1.38			
I trust this nonprofit brand to conduct its operations ethically.	5.13	1.37			
I trust this nonprofit brand to use donated funds appropriately.	5.05	1.40			
Source: Based on Sargeant and Woodliffe (2007)					
Nonprofit Brand Commitment			0.91	0.92	0.95
The relationship I have with this nonprofit brand is something I am very committed to.	3.88	1.70			
The relationship I have with this nonprofit brand is something I intend to maintain indefinitely.	3.64	1.68			
The relationship I have with this nonprofit brand deserves maximum effort to maintain.	3.84	1.71			
Source: Based on Sargeant and Lee (2004)					
Discriminant Validity					
Nonprofit brand trust	0.88				
Nonprofit brand commitment	0.26		0.91		

Notes: M = Mean; SD = Standard deviation; AVE = Average variance extracted; CR = Composite reliability; α = Cronbach's alpha. Discriminant Validity: Boldface values are AVEs; value below represents squared correlation value.

value of 0.70. Composite reliability was above the minimum value of 0.60, and the values for the average variance extracted surpassed the recommended threshold of 0.50 (Fornell and Larcker 1981). To assess discriminant validity, Fornell and Larcker (1981) have also suggested that the average variance extracted should exceed the squared correlation value between the construct pair, which is true in our case.

Methodology

For each of the considered brands, the index was built from the brands' public awareness (BA), and the weights (w) of brand trust (BT) and brand commitment (BC) (calculated based on the results of the structural equation model) and mean values ($\bar{x}$) of these constructs. This resulted in the following calculation formula:

$$\text{Nonprofit Brand Equity Index} = BA \times \frac{w_{BT} \bar{x}_{BT}}{7w_{BT}} \times \frac{w_{BC} \bar{x}_{BC}}{7w_{BC}} \times 100$$

Accordingly, we first included brand awareness in the index by using the percentages of the awareness scale that is shown in Table 3. This approach is consistent with nonprofit and for-profit branding literature stating that brand awareness is a precondition for further interaction with the brand and acts as a basis for a stakeholder–brand relationship. Considering the overall low recall rates of brands and organizations in the nonprofit sector, we primarily focus on the aided brand awareness dimension because it is regarded a more robust measure in this case. For the relationship-related nonprofit brand equity dimensions, that is, brand trust and brand commitment, we then calculated weights using a reflective-formative measurement approach based on prior studies on index building (for example, Gardó et al. 2014; Guinot, Latreille, and Tenenhaus 2001; see also Becker, Klein, and Wetzels 2012; Diamantopoulos, Riefler, and Roth 2008; Diamantopoulos and Winklhofer 2001; Interbrand 2015). The use of formative indicators to operationalize marketing constructs has gained increasing importance over the past years (Diamantopoulos 2008), and is particularly appropriate when the index does not exist as an independent entity, and is rather a composite measure that includes several dimensions. Precisely, the approach involves estimating a hierarchical (second-order) formative measurement model (with reflective first-order dimensions in our case), to capture distinct factors that jointly describe the formatively measured construct. That is, “relationship-related nonprofit brand equity” equals an overall index variable (Diamantopoulos and Winklhofer 2001) and is created from the concatenation of the relationship-related brand equity dimensions nonprofit brand trust and nonprofit brand commitment. We particularly used a repeated indicator approach because of its ability to estimate all constructs simultaneously (Becker et al. 2012; Lohmöller 1989). We estimated the model with PLS path modeling (with SmartPLS3; Ringle, Wende, and Becker 2014), which provided the weights for trust and commitment in the construction of the index. In addition to the respective weights obtained through the analysis, we used the trust and commitment mean values of each nonprofit brand to calculate the brands’ individual index scores. To increase the readability of the index and set the highest index score to 100, the value was multiplied by 100 in a final step.

Application of the Nonprofit Brand Equity Index

To apply the nonprofit brand equity index, we conducted two successive, quantitative online studies. These enabled us to ultimately provide a ranking of forty nonprofit brands according to their brand equity index scores.

Study Design

In May 2014, we conducted the first stage of data collection (pre-study) to generate a comprehensive list of the best-known German nonprofit brand names. We collaborated with the research laboratory of the university, surveying a random student sample ($N=114$) to investigate the brand awareness of 216 preselected German and international (with headquarters in Germany) nonprofit brands. The preselection of brand names was based on several sources (Deutscher Spendenrat 2014; Deutsches Zentralinstitut für Soziale Fragen [DZI] 2009; Gesellschaft für Konsumforschung [GfK] 2009).

For the second stage (main study), we split our list into well-known ($N=108$) and less well-known nonprofit organizations, according to their degree of brand awareness (top-of-mind, unaided, and aided brand awareness) from the pre-study. All subsequent assessments were

then based on the well-known brands (that is, 108 brand names). In July 2014, we collaborated with a large global market research company to collect data in a stand-alone survey. The survey was representative with respect to age, gender, and region/federal state for the German population according to the Census Bureau ($N=2,052$; US Census Bureau 2014; to collect representative samples, the market research company usually refers to the international database of the US Census Bureau, regardless from which country the sample is selected). In the first part of the questionnaire, all respondents assessed the 108 considered organizations with respect to their degree of brand awareness; for sample characteristics see Table 2.

In the second part of the questionnaire, the respondents were asked to rate up to three randomly selected nonprofit brands (depending on which brands were known by the participant) with respect to nonprofit brand trust and nonprofit brand commitment. This procedure created varying numbers of assessments for different brands, leading to brands with fewer than twenty and others with more than fifty or a hundred evaluations. To ensure high measurement quality, we excluded 366 respondents because they gave the same answer to all assessed nonprofit brand dimensions. For index application, we included only brands with more than twenty evaluations, as otherwise no valid results would be obtained; this resulted in a total number of forty assessed nonprofit brands; yielding 3,617 brand evaluations.

Results

Table 3 shows the results for the forty nonprofit brands ranked by the overall index score. The weights obtained from the analysis are the same for all brands with a brand trust weight of 0.56 ($p < 0.001$) and a brand commitment weight of 0.59 ($p < 0.001$). The results indicate that with an index score of 37.90, German Red Cross had the highest value, assigning it as the strongest nonprofit brand (highest brand equity) within the selected sample of forty organizations. Additional high-scoring nonprofit brands are internationally operating organizations, such as UNICEF (34.88) and Greenpeace (24.63). Moreover, nonprofit brands of organizations that focus on supporting children (for example, BILD helps “A Heart for Children” [25.35], RTL Children in Need Foundation [22.04], German Children’s Fund [18.86]), and nonprofit brands of foundations that fight diseases (for example, German AIDS Foundation [18.76], German Heart Foundation [17.85]) receive comparatively high index scores as well.

Discussion

This study contributes to the ongoing debate by conceptualizing and operationalizing nonprofit brand equity and by introducing an accordant measurement index. As such, it offers novel contributions to research in nonprofit branding, and valuable recommendations for nonprofit managers and leaders; still, it has some limitations that provide the basis for further research.

Research Issues and Limitations

Nonprofit managers and leaders increasingly recognize the potential of branding in the nonprofit sector, acknowledging the benefits of strong nonprofit brands (Kent 2015). This study highlights the importance of stakeholder-based nonprofit brand equity and conceptualizes and

Table 2. Sample Characteristics and Criteria for Representative Status (*N* = 2,052)

	Category	Sample		National Sample
		N	Percentage	Percentage
Age	14–19	171	8.33	9.00
	20–29	366	17.84	18.00
	30–39	358	17.45	18.00
	40–49	484	23.59	24.00
	50–59	470	22.90	23.00
	60–64	203	9.89	9.00
Gender	Female	1,029	50.15	49.47
	Male	1,023	49.85	50.53
Federal State	Baden-Württemberg	269	13.11	13.20
	Bayern	316	15.40	15.40
	Berlin	87	4.24	4.30
	Brandenburg	62	3.02	3.00
	Bremen	16	0.78	0.08
	Hamburg	48	2.34	2.20
	Hessen	150	7.31	7.40
	Mecklenburg-Vorpommern	39	1.90	2.00
	Niedersachsen	192	9.36	9.70
	Nordrhein-Westfalen	451	21.98	21.80
	Rheinland-Pfalz	103	5.02	4.90
	Saarland	23	1.12	1.20
	Sachsen	108	5.26	5.10
	Sachsen-Anhalt	58	2.83	2.80
	Schleswig-Holstein	74	3.61	3.50
	Thüringen	56	2.73	2.70
Monthly Net Income	No income	79	3.85	
	< 1,000 euros	495	24.12	
	1,000–3,999 euros	1,157	56.38	
	> 4,000 euros	104	5.06	
	Missing responses	217	10.58	
Religion	No religious affiliation	954	46.50	
	Religious affiliation	1,098	53.50	
Education	No degree/not yet a degree	108	5.27	
	Completed school education	510	24.85	
	Apprenticeship	968	47.17	
	Bachelor's/master's/ diploma	410	19.98	
	MBA/PhD	56	2.73	

Table 3. Nonprofit Brands According to Their Brand Equity Index Scores

	Nonprofit Brand Name (English translation, if suitable)	N Brand Evaluations	Nonprofit Brand			Overall Index Score
			Awareness	Trust (Mean)	Commitment (Mean)	
1	German Red Cross	40	0.84	5.13	4.31	37.90
2	Aktion Mensch	21	0.82	4.95	4.27	35.37
3	German Committee for UNICEF	41	0.78	5.12	4.28	34.88
4	BILD helps "A Heart for Children"	336	0.68	4.95	3.69	25.35
5	Greenpeace	27	0.72	4.67	3.59	24.63
6	WEISSER RING	22	0.53	4.99	4.36	23.53
7	RTL Children in Need Foundation	102	0.56	5.01	3.85	22.04
8	German Children's Fund	39	0.48	5.00	3.85	18.86
9	German AIDS Foundation	23	0.39	5.48	4.30	18.76
10	German Association for Child Protection	289	0.42	5.42	3.91	18.16
11	German Heart Foundation	46	0.41	4.87	4.38	17.85
12	The social welfare organization of Germany's Protestant churches	21	0.52	4.70	3.43	17.11
13	Federal Association for People with Intellectual Disabilities	336	0.35	5.24	3.79	14.19
14	Kindernothilfe	25	0.31	5.12	4.32	13.99
15	Diakonie Katastrophenhilfe	37	0.31	4.75	4.02	12.08
16	Kolping Society of Germany	205	0.33	4.72	3.35	10.65
17	v. Bodelschwingh Institutions Bethel	95	0.25	5.27	3.95	10.62
18	Aktion Deutschland Hilft	41	0.28	4.85	3.81	10.56
19	German Emergency Doctors	215	0.24	5.50	3.59	9.67
20	McDonald's Children's Charity	20	0.25	4.75	3.93	9.52
21	Karl Heinz Boehm Foundation	107	0.22	5.34	3.92	9.40
22	German José Carreras Leukaemia Foundation	152	0.20	5.58	3.90	8.88
23	German War Graves Commission	76	0.26	4.91	3.37	8.78
24	Hamburger Tafel	32	0.19	5.26	4.21	8.59
25	German Leukemia Research Aid	119	0.17	5.54	4.20	8.07
26	German Young Men's Christian Association (YMCA)	259	0.28	4.70	2.91	7.82
27	Children's Fund for Children in the Third World	128	0.19	5.10	3.74	7.40
28	German Society of Multiple Sclerosis	65	0.14	5.55	4.51	7.15
29	Children's Missionary Organization "Sternsinger"	72	0.14	5.56	4.12	6.54
30	German Foundation for Monument Protection	87	0.15	5.12	4.00	6.27
31	Robert Bosch Foundation	20	0.14	5.12	4.27	6.25

Table 3. (Continued)

	Nonprofit Brand Name (English translation, if suitable)	N Brand Evaluations	Nonprofit Brand			Overall Index Score
			Awareness	Trust (Mean)	Commitment (Mean)	
32	Schweitzer Children's Village	39	0.15	5.28	3.43	5.54
33	Aktion Lichtblicke	93	0.13	5.53	3.77	5.53
34	Worldwide Help for Children	44	0.12	5.19	4.26	5.41
35	CARE Germany-Luxembourg	113	0.15	4.94	3.35	5.07
36	ADVENIAT	53	0.14	4.81	3.35	4.60
37	Herzenswünsche	58	0.10	5.48	4.00	4.47
38	International Confederation for Youth, Social Work, Education, Labour Market Services	56	0.07	4.92	3.83	2.69
39	ChildFund Germany	36	0.05	5.10	3.95	2.06
40	German National Academic Foundation	27	0.05	4.58	3.96	1.85

Note: The weights obtained from PLS path modeling are the same for all brands with a trust weight of 0.56 ($p < 0.001$) and a commitment weight of 0.59 ($p < 0.001$).

operationalizes the construct by developing an initial brand equity index for nonprofit organizations. Against this background, this study contributes to recent branding discussions in the nonprofit sector in three main ways.

First, we addressed the limited research on nonprofit brand building, supplementing prior studies that focused on the composition of nonprofit brands in terms of brand strength and brand equity (Faircloth 2005; Hou et al. 2009; Laidler-Kylander and Simonin 2009; Wymer et al. 2015). From a review of for-profit and nonprofit branding and relationship literature, and building on discussions on nonprofit governance and accountability, we conceptualized nonprofit brand equity as having three dimensions: nonprofit brand awareness, nonprofit brand trust, and nonprofit brand commitment. Although dimensions of brand awareness and relationship-related constructs such as brand commitment have played a prominent role in nonprofit brand equity research, this study contributes to the nonprofit brand equity discussion by acknowledging the high importance of trust (Kearns 2014). High levels of public trust are indispensable in the nonprofit sector, but trust has received less attention in the nonprofit brand equity discussion. In accordance with findings from explorative nonprofit brand equity research (Laidler-Kylander and Simonin 2009), we found that public trust in brands plays a major role in nonprofit brand building, thereby advancing conceptual and empirical research in this area. In view of the limited research on conceptualizations of nonprofit brand equity that considers brands' and organizations' special characteristics in the nonprofit sector (Laidler-Kylander and Simonin 2009), this study provides initial insights into the nonprofit brand equity concept and therefore is not without restrictions. Other nonprofit scholars should verify the proposed framework by conducting further empirical research in the field.

Second, prior research has operationalized measures of nonprofit brand equity on the basis of different brand dimensions, using point-rating scales (for example, Faircloth 2005; Hou et al.

2009) that aid in summing up and calculating the averages of each dimension. Prior studies and practical investigations (for example, Gardó et al. 2014; Interbrand 2015) largely regard weighting methods of the respective dimensions as an adequate approach for operationalizing overall constructs such as nonprofit brand equity. In this sense, and with the advent of the use of formative indicators (Diamantopoulos 2008), we used a second-order formative measurement model, thereby capturing the distinct brand dimensions. Because brand awareness is considered a precondition in nonprofit brand building, we measured brand awareness as an aided measure, so we cannot account for its weight and, thus, its importance for overall brand equity and relative to the other dimensions. Although such measures are widely accepted in academic literature, they exhibit limited applicability; further research could include point-rating scales to account for the importance of this dimension (see Wymer et al. 2015).

Third, we address the lack of studies on nonprofit brand evaluation approaches by introducing an initial index that supports a stakeholder-based perspective and provides important insights into the strength of brands. We built the nonprofit brand equity index using external stakeholders' assessment of the strength of their familiarity and relationship with the brand. The higher the overall index score, the higher are these stakeholders' assessments of brand equity. Based on the fact that we applied the index to a sample of forty nonprofit brands, there is potential for applying the index to larger organizational samples and for longitudinal measurements.

Implications

This study provides the basis for several useful recommendations for nonprofit managers and leaders. As a first managerial implication, we encourage nonprofit managers to apply a more strategic approach to the practice of nonprofit branding. Engaging in nonprofit branding efforts is a worthwhile endeavor for nonprofit organizations because strong nonprofit brands are generally related to important organizational outcomes. Accordingly, we advise managers to gain insights into nonprofit brand equity measurement related to brand awareness, brand trust, and brand commitment. Strong exchange relationships with trusting and committed stakeholders can enhance the strategic options for nonprofit managers and encourage them to cooperate with stakeholders and maintain a long-term orientation (Kemp et al. 2014). The considered dimensions build on each other and, by focusing on all dimensions together, managers can enhance the public's attitude toward the nonprofit brand and improve its strategic position in the market.

Moreover, achieving high brand equity can protect organizations against negative spillover effects occurred from scandals in the nonprofit sector. As such, strong brands (with high equity) can function partly as a trust and quality seal.

Our proposed nonprofit brand equity index provides an integrated performance indicator for both nonprofit managers and stakeholders; it is designed to be manageable but still yield meaningful results. As such, the index offers significant insights into the three important strategic brand dimensions. It thereby shows to what degree the nonprofit brand is able to function as an additional safeguard to the public in terms of a positive public attitude toward the organization, particularly relating to credibility and trustworthiness. Managers could use the overall index score as well as the respective single results for strategic decision making because it provides the basis for nonprofit branding strategies and measures. For example, if

a nonprofit brand scores high on brand awareness but low on brand trust and brand commitment, nonprofit organizations should develop branding strategies that enhance trust in the nonprofit brand first. In contrast, if a nonprofit brand scores comparatively high on brand trust and brand commitment but is less known in the public's mind, managers should consider investing in awareness-generating campaigns first, which might leverage the stakeholder–brand relationships and ultimately strengthen the brand.

Furthermore, nonprofit managers can conduct comparisons with other nonprofit brands and for comparisons over time. Brand evaluations may serve as a compass in nonprofit organizations that have an ultimate goal of obtaining an optimal positioning while maintaining strong exchange relationships with stakeholders.

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